

DREAMING AGES HISTORY · EPISODE 12 · BONUS

Day of the Dead

Sleep Story for Adults

A Candlelit Día de Muertos in Mixquic

✦ ✦ ✦

A BEDTIME COMPANION

Two maps, a timeline from an island town around 1500 to the candles of the Alumbrada, the people and places you'll meet in the episode, and a short list of trusted books and museums, for the evenings when you would like to wander a little further.

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AN ISLAND TOWN AT THE EDGE OF THE CITY

Where the story happens

Let's begin at the edge of the city, in an old island town.



Places plotted at their real locations on a modern base map (Natural Earth). Lake Chalco, around Mixquic, was drained from the 1890s and is not shown.

AT A GLANCE

- Around 1500, Mixquic was an island town in Lake Chalco
- Today it lies on the southern edge of Mexico City
- On the night of 2 November its churchyard fills with candles

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Places you'll visit in the episode

Twelve places from the episode, from Mixquic to Aguascalientes.

San Andrés Mixquic · Once an island town in Lake Chalco, now on the southern edge of Mexico City; home of the Alumbrada.

Lake Chalco · The shallow lake of chinampas, long narrow fields between canals, around Mixquic.

Mexico City · The Mexica city of Tenochtitlan, later the capital of New Spain and of Mexico.

The Portales · The arcades of the great square, where sugar figures were sold at All Saints.

The Alameda · The park beside which Diego Rivera painted his great mural in 1946–47.

Lake Pátzcuaro · In Michoacán: the island of Janitzio and its Night of the Dead vigil.

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Places you'll visit in the episode

Toluca · The Feria del Alfeñique, a fair of sugar figures held in the Portales.

San Salvador Huixcolotla · In Puebla, where papel picado is cut in stacks with hammer and chisels.

Oaxaca · Pan de yema with little dough faces, and dark mole.

Yucatán · Hanal Pixán, "food of the souls", and a great tamal baked in an earth oven.

Ocotepec · In Morelos, where homes with a new ofrenda welcome visitors who bring candles.

Aguascalientes · Where José Guadalupe Posada was born in 1852.

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FIVE HUNDRED YEARS, AND MORE

A timeline of the festival

From an island town around 1500 to the first parade, one quiet step at a time.

AT A GLANCE

1570s
Durán sees the offerings

1840–1841
Calderón's sugar skulls

c. 1910
The lady in the big hat

c. 1500 — Mixquic is an island town in Lake Chalco, ringed by chinampas.

1427/28–1440 — In the reign of Itzcóatl the Mexica conquer Mixquic; the Codex Mendoza lists it.

1519 — Spanish ships arrive on the eastern coast.

1521 — Tenochtitlan falls.

1524 — A small group of Franciscan friars arrives.

1536 — Augustinian friars found the house of San Andrés at Mixquic (or the year after).

c. 1563 — The church and friars' house at Mixquic are finished.

1570s — Diego Durán sees offerings for children on All Saints and for adults on All Souls.

1583 — Sahagún's Psalmodia Christiana, songs in Nahuatl for the feasts, is printed in Mexico City.

FIVE HUNDRED YEARS, AND MORE

A timeline of the festival

The story goes on from here, slowly.



1620 — The present church front at Mixquic; after an earthquake only the bell tower is older.

1763–1766 — Francisco de Ajofrín sees sugar-paste lambs and little figures sold under the arcades.

1821 — Mexico wins its independence.

1840–1841 — Madame Calderón de la Barca writes of the Día de Muertos and the sugar skulls.

1844 — Zorrilla's play Don Juan Tenorio, later staged around All Saints.

1859 — A law of Juárez's government secularises cemeteries.

1895 — The drainage of Lake Chalco is granted to the Noriega brothers.

c. 1910 — Posada draws the skull lady in the big hat.

FIVE HUNDRED YEARS, AND MORE

A timeline of the festival

1913 — Posada dies in January; later that year the lady is first printed, as a “garbancera”.

1931–1936 — The Morelos monument on Janitzio, ordered by Governor Lázaro Cárdenas.

1946–1947 — Diego Rivera paints Dream of a Sunday Afternoon in the Alameda.

1970s–1980s — Chicano artists set up public Day of the Dead altars in the United States.

1985 — An earthquake damages the hotel; the mural moves to its own museum, opened in 1988.

2003 & 2008 — UNESCO proclaims, then inscribes, the Indigenous festivity dedicated to the dead.

2016 — Mexico City’s first Day of the Dead parade, inspired by a 2015 film.

Early dates are approximate. Historians still discuss how much of the festival comes from the Mexica world and how much came from Spain; most agree it grew from both.

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From the lake to the wider world

Now let's step back and see how far the customs have travelled.



Places named in the episode, on a modern base map (Natural Earth). Public altars in Los Angeles and San Francisco date from the 1970s–80s; in Sumpango, Guatemala, giant kites fly over the cemeteries on 1 November.

People you'll meet

The friars, writers, artists and families you'll meet along the way.

Citlalin & Tochtli · An imagined grandmother and grandson on the chinampas around 1500.

Mictlantecuhtli & Mictecacihuatl · The lord and the lady of Mictlan, the place of the dead.

Bernardino de Sahagún · Franciscan who recorded Nahua accounts of the road to Mictlan and the yellow dog.

Diego Durán · Dominican friar who saw offerings for the "little" and the "great" dead.

Jorge de Ávila & Jerónimo de San Esteban · Augustinian friars who came to Mixquic in 1536.

Francisco de Ajofrín · Capuchin friar who saw the sugar figures under the arcades.

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People you'll meet

Madame Calderón de la Barca · Scottish-born author of Life in Mexico (1843).

Guillermo Prieto · Mexican writer who remembered the bakeries at this season.

José Guadalupe Posada · Printmaker of comic skeletons and the lady in the big hat.

Antonio Vanegas Arroyo · Mexico City publisher of cheap broadsheets and calaveras.

Diego Rivera · Muralist who gave the skull lady a body, and perhaps her name.

Doña Elena, Rosa, Martín & Lupe · An imagined Mixquic family of today.

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WHILE YOU LISTEN

Things to spot, legend and history

A few things to listen for, and a note on legend and history.

THINGS TO SPOT IN THE EPISODE

- The small yellow dog at the river of the nine waters
- Old women calling “Skulls, girls, skulls!” under the arcades
- The lady in the enormous feathered hat
- Children with a hand bell: “Campanero, mi tamal”
- A field of small, steady flames at the Alumbrada

LEGEND OR HISTORY?

La Catrina is not an Aztec goddess: Posada drew her around 1910 as a joke about fashion, and Rivera gave her a body in 1946–47. Day of the Dead is not “Mexican Halloween”, and it is neither an unchanged Aztec festival nor purely Spanish: the Mexica months of the dead fell in late summer, while candles, wheat bread and sugar came from Spain. The Mexico City parade began in 2016, and Mixquic means “at the mesquite”, not “place of death”. The families in the episode are imagined; the customs are real.





Artistic impressions of the Alumbrada at Mixquic and of sugar skulls, made for the episode. They are not historical records.

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Books to read

If you'd like to wander a little further, here are some trusted places to start.

Skulls to the Living, Bread to the Dead ↗, Stanley Brandes (Blackwell, 2006).

Life in Mexico ↗, Frances Calderón de la Barca (University of California Press, 1982).

Book of the Gods and Rites and the Ancient Calendar ↗, Fray Diego Durán, trans. Fernando Horcasitas and Doris Heyden (University of Oklahoma Press).

Embodying Mexico ↗, Ruth Hellier-Tinoco (Oxford University Press, 2011).

The Aztecs ↗, Michael E. Smith (Wiley-Blackwell).

📚 FIND THESE BOOKS — TAP HERE →

Full reading list ↗

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Museums, places and one last thought

Museums & places

Museo Nacional de Antropología, Mexico City.

Museo del Templo Mayor, Mexico City: offerings, including copal.

Museo Mural Diego Rivera, beside the Alameda: Dream of a Sunday Afternoon in the Alameda.

In Mixquic: the community museum and the churchyard of San Andrés.

A BEDTIME QUESTION

If you set a small light tonight for someone you remember, whose name would you write on the sugar skull?

"The table is laid. The path of petals leads to the door. Everyone who is remembered has been remembered."

LISTEN TO THE FULL EPISODE ON YOUTUBE OR YOUTUBE MUSIC

Watch the episode: youtube.com/watch?v=R5GMinpeddA

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